

Claude Code on Windows — Setup Cheatsheet

Keep this open. Follow it step by step. ~15 minutes start to finish.

What you're installing and why

Thing	What it is
Windows Terminal	The window with tabs. Already on Windows 11.
PowerShell	The "language" you type inside the window. Already there.
Node.js	A piece of software that includes <code>npm</code> , the installer Claude Code uses.
Claude Code	The AI assistant itself.

Why PowerShell and not something else? PowerShell is built into Windows, modern, and Microsoft maintains it. CMD is the old one — skip it. Git Bash is fine but an extra install. WSL2 (Linux on Windows) is the most powerful option — try it once you're comfortable.

Step 1 — Install Node.js

1. Open your browser. Go to <https://nodejs.org>
2. Click the **LTS** download button (the green one on the left).
3. Run the downloaded installer.
4. Click **Next** on every screen. Defaults are correct.
5. Click **Install**. Wait until it finishes.
6. Close any PowerShell windows that were open. Open a fresh one.

Test it worked. Open PowerShell (press `Win`, type "Terminal", press Enter). Paste:

```
node --version  
npm --version
```

You should see two version numbers like `v20.11.0` and `10.2.4`. If you see "not recognized" — close PowerShell and open a new window.

Step 2 — Install Claude Code

In PowerShell, paste this and press Enter:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Wait 30–60 seconds. When the prompt comes back, test it:

```
claude --version
```

If you get a permission error: Close PowerShell. Right-click the PowerShell icon and choose **Run as administrator**. Try the install command again.

Step 3 — Sign in

In PowerShell, type:

```
claude
```

A first-run screen appears. Choose **"Sign in with Claude account."**

A browser window opens. Log in with your Claude.ai account, click **Authorize**, then go back to PowerShell. You're in.

No Claude.ai account? Sign up free at claude.ai. To use Claude Code regularly, get the Pro plan (\$20/mo).

Step 4 — Try it

1. On your Desktop, make a folder called `claude-test`.
2. In PowerShell, run:

```
cd $HOME\Desktop\claude-test  
claude
```

3. At the prompt, type:

"Make me a simple HTML page that lists my top 3 favorite books with a one-sentence review for each. Open it in my browser when done."

Watch what happens. Claude will create a file, ask permission, and open it for you.

Useful commands

Command	What it does
<code>claude</code>	Start Claude in the current folder
<code>claude --resume</code>	Continue your last conversation
<code>/help</code>	Inside Claude, shows all commands
<code>/clear</code>	Inside Claude, start a fresh conversation
<code>/skills</code>	Inside Claude, see available pre-built experts
<code>cd path\to\folder</code>	Move PowerShell to a folder
<code>exit</code> (or Ctrl+D)	Leave Claude

Common problems and fixes

Problem	Fix
<code>node</code> is "not recognized" after install	Close PowerShell. Open a new window. Try again.
<code>npm install</code> fails with permission error	Run PowerShell as Administrator (right-click → Run as admin).
<code>claude</code> won't start	Make sure Node installed. Run <code>npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code</code> again.
Browser doesn't open during sign-in	Copy the URL it printed and paste into your browser manually.
Emoji or special characters look like boxes	In Windows Terminal: Settings → Profiles → PowerShell → Appearance → Font face → "Cascadia Mono".
Want to start over	Run <code>claude</code> then type <code>/logout</code> . Then <code>claude</code> again to sign in fresh.

What to learn next

- **CLAUDE.md** — Drop a text file called `CLAUDE.md` in any folder. Whatever you write inside teaches Claude your preferences for that folder. Example: "I run a Shopify store. Always answer in Arabic. Never edit files in /backups."
 - **Skills** — Pre-built experts. Type `/skills` inside Claude to see them.
 - **MCP servers** — Connect Claude to outside tools (Gmail, Google Drive, Shopify, etc.).
 - **WSL2** — Run real Linux inside Windows. More powerful, more setup. Worth it once you're comfortable.
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Where to get help

- Inside Claude, type `/help`
- Docs: <https://docs.claude.com/claude-code>
- Report bugs: <https://github.com/anthropics/claude-code/issues>